2.2.14 Finding Layouts

To find the current layout, Rails first looks for a file in `app/views/layouts` with the same base name as the controller. For example, rendering actions from the `PhotosController` class will use `app/views/layouts/photos.html.erb` (or `app/views/layouts/photos.builder`). If there is no such controller-specific layout, Rails will use `app/views/layouts/application.html.erb` or `app/views/layouts/application.builder`. If there is no `.erb` layout, Rails will use a `.builder`layout if one exists. Rails also provides several ways to more precisely assign specific layouts to individual controllers and actions.

2.2.14.1 Specifying Layouts for Controllers

You can override the default layout conventions in your controllers by using the `layout` declaration. For example:

```
class ProductsController < ApplicationController
  layout "inventory"
  #...
end
```

With this declaration, all of the views rendered by the `ProductsController` will use `app/views/layouts/inventory.html.erb` as their layout.

To assign a specific layout for the entire application, use a `layout` declaration in your `ApplicationController` class:

```
class ApplicationController < ActionController::Base
  layout "main"
  #...
end
```

With this declaration, all of the views in the entire application will use `app/views/layouts/main.html.erb` for their layout.

2.2.14.2 Choosing Layouts at Runtime

You can use a symbol to defer the choice of layout until a request is processed:

```
class ProductsController < ApplicationController
  layout :products_layout

  def show
    @product = Product.find(params[:id])
  end

  private
    def products_layout
      @current_user.special? ? "special" : "products"
    end

end
```

Now, if the current user is a special user, they'll get a special layout when viewing a product.

You can even use an inline method, such as a Proc, to determine the layout. For example, if you pass a Proc object, the block you give the Proc will be given the `controller` instance, so the layout can be determined based on the current request:

```
class ProductsController < ApplicationController
  layout Proc.new { |controller| controller.request.xhr? ? "popup" :
"application" }
end
```

2.2.14.3 Conditional Layouts